

Rhea Madhogarhia

Haitham Ibrahim

Media Aesthetics | Section 9

Due October 21st

Reality as the Form of a Story

In the film *Close-Up*, director Kiarostami follows the trial and arrest, and explores the identity of Hossain Sabzian, a man who impersonates a famous Iranian filmmaker, Makhmalbaf. Kiarostami not only records the story on camera, but is present as the story unfolds and even captures the events leading up to and following Sabzian's trial as they occur. As a result, *Close-Up* blurs the lines between what is real and scripted in the film for the viewer. Imitation plays an important part in the movie because, not only is it a film about a filmmaker creating a film, but also because the film is being created as we watch it. The viewers are witnessing the creation of the media they are consuming while grappling with whether the media is an imitation, reality, or both, something that Plato in *Republic* does not believe can exist. While Plato disagrees that truthfulness and imitation in an artform can coexist, Kiarostami challenges this idea in *Close-Up* through his hyper-realistic filmmaking style that makes reality and recreation almost indistinguishable from each other.

Although imitation and forms are opposing ideas to Plato, Kiarostami, by having the characters play themselves, blends these two concepts and makes the imitations of the characters in the film the same as the forms they were based off of. Throughout Book 10 of *Republic*, Plato develops his theory of forms and claims that our physical world is not reality. Instead, Plato's "true reality" is seen through ideas innate in our mind rather than through our eyes. Plato goes as far to say that most, if not all, of what we see in our lives is an imitation of their real forms and that, "imitation is surely far removed from the truth.... it grasps only a small part of each thing - and that is an illusion" (Plato, 301). In *Close-Up*, many of the characters in the film, Sabzian, Makhmalbaf, and Kiarostami, to name a few, all portray themselves. Usually, directors hire actors they think can fulfill their idea of a written character; in this case, the character would be the form of a persona in a film and the actor would be the imitation of that form. By having the protagonist, Sabzian, play himself, and for so many of the scenes to be unscripted, the film is not just an imitation of Sabzian's story, it is a capture of the "form" of Sabzian's real life. Here, the illusion is not the story Kiarostami is telling; if anything, Kiarostami is not telling a story, he is

showing us the form of the story he wants to tell, the actual events which occurred. The real illusion here is using film, an artform that usually uses imitation to tell a story to show us real life events. In this way, Kiarostami melds the illusory nature of film with the form of Sabzian's story. In other, likely staged, parts of the film, Kiarostami still manages to make the audience feel as though they are living through the film rather than just viewing it.

While film is arguably an inherently imitative art form, Kiarostami's choice to include seemingly trivial yet realistic scenes in *Close-Up* forces the audience to experience those scenes as they would in real life. Plato reinforces his distinctions between forms and illusions and makes clear that he thinks artists cannot make realistic art in Book 10: "We should consider, then...when they see their works, that they are three removed from what is, and are easy to produce without knowledge of the truth. For they produce illusions, not things that are" (Plato, 302). Kiarostami does not necessarily produce things that "are" all throughout the film, but he does affect viewers of the movie in a real way because of how truthful to reality some scenes are. For example, Kiarostami decides to include approximately 10 seconds of a spray can rolling down the street, unaccompanied by music or editing. Upon first watch of the movie, this scene feels oddly long to watch and makes the viewer question why such a mundane and seemingly random scene would be included. Upon further inspection, if you were to place yourself at the scene being filmed, maybe as a director or as a passerby, you would likely also watch the can roll down the incline without time jumps or a soundtrack. Kiarostami is showing reality in a way that forces the viewer to question how they feel about what has been shown to them. In this way, watching the film becomes an interactive experience that viewers can easily participate in, feeling emotions similar to those which the film's characters may feel in that moment.

Many people describe *Close-Up* as a docu-fiction film due to the mix of recreated and unscripted scenes, which begs the question, is Kiarostami's approach to realism in film revolutionary compared to other directors who produce documentary style films? Is *Close-Up* not just another documentary? What Kiarostami does differently is he creates the illusion of telling a fictional story while simultaneously showing us the actual events on which the story is based. His ability to show audiences the "form" of the movie invests the viewers into deciphering what is real, subsequently making them tap into the emotions they'd feel if they had lived through the story themselves. Kiarostami's imitation of a fictional film is almost more effective at documentary style storytelling, which often has the purpose of shedding light on awareness worthy stories, than traditional documentary films, because it informs and educates the viewer on what living through the documentary's events would have been like.

Works Cited

Close-Up. Directed by Abbas Kiarostami, Institute for the Intellectual Development of Children and Young Adults, 1999.

Plato. *Republic*. Translated by Reeve C D C., Hackett Publishing Company, Inc., 2004.